

Eighty Years of Asking

What the NSHD asked its study members at each stage of life — from the maternity survey in 1946 through to today.

Across 40 sweeps since 1946, the NSHD has asked its study members a different set of questions at every stage of life — shaped by what mattered most at each age, and by what the science of the time could measure. This timeline groups those 40 sweeps into nine chapters, each covering what was actually asked and why.

For the full sweep-by-sweep detail — responding population, data collection methods, and the original annotated questionnaire PDFs — see NSHD Questionnaires at rmjdish.github.io/OWL/docs/questionnaires/NSHD_questionnaires_homepage.html. This document is the introduction; that page is the reference.



Infancy and the family

1946–1948 · birth to age 2

The study began with the **1946 Maternity Survey**, interviewing mothers about the birth itself, antenatal care, and the household's circumstances. The earliest questions were as much about the family the child was born into as the child — the mother's health and work, the home and its conditions, and the wider family's finances.

Follow-up surveys at ages 1 and 2 tracked early infant care and continued to build a picture of the household. A separate **1960 Fertility Questionnaire** later returned to some of these same mothers to ask about marriage, further pregnancies, and family size intentions since the birth of the cohort child.

[See the 1946–1948 questionnaires and PDFs on NSHD Questionnaires →](#)



Growing up: school, health and ability

1950–1959 · ages 4–13

Through the 1950s, questionnaires to mothers, schools, and school doctors tracked childhood illness, hospital admissions, and school attendance — alongside more everyday details like hobbies and outside interests. This decade also introduced the study's first standardised testing: a General Ability Test, a Mechanical Reading and Word Comprehension test, an Arithmetic Test, and a Handwriting Test, sat directly by the study members themselves.

[See the 1950s questionnaires and PDFs on NSHD Questionnaires →](#)



Adolescence: ability, school and ambition

1961–1965 · ages 15–19

As study members entered secondary school and beyond, testing became more sophisticated — the Alice Heim (AH4) reasoning test, the Watts-Vernon reading test, and a mathematics test sat alongside questions on class details, punctuality, truancy, and attitude to schoolwork. Parental health and employment, further pregnancies in the family, and the study members' own employment ambitions and social activities were also tracked as they approached the choice between further education and work.

[See the 1961–1965 questionnaires and PDFs on NSHD Questionnaires](#) →



Becoming independent adults

1966–1972 · ages 20–26

The content shifts noticeably here, away from childhood and school and toward independent adult life: marital status and children, household and housing information, heights and weights, and detailed employment history and earnings. Newer question areas appeared too — nervous strain, religion, siblings, attitudes to social class, and even social and political attitudes and electoral behaviour — reflecting study members now old enough to have views of their own on the world around them.

[See the 1966–1972 questionnaires and PDFs on NSHD Questionnaires](#) →



Establishing adult life

1977–1989 · ages 31–43

By their thirties, study members' questionnaires covered the practicalities of established adult life — housing, marriage, children's schooling, employment history, training, and financial hardship — alongside home life, social and leisure activities, and significant life events. This period also marks the study's first systematic health screening beyond childhood: the Rose Angina questionnaire and the MRC questionnaire on chest and cough symptoms, plus questions on diet, smoking, exercise, and blood pressure — the beginnings of tracking cardiovascular and respiratory health across the cohort.

[See the 1977–1989 questionnaires and PDFs on NSHD Questionnaires](#) →



The Women's Health sub-study

1993–2005 · ages 47–59

Running **alongside** the general sweeps rather than in sequence with them, the Women's Health in the Middle Years sub-study followed the women of the cohort through midlife in far more depth than the general survey alone — tracking the menopause, hormone replacement therapy, and hysterectomy or oophorectomy, alongside midlife health changes and symptoms more broadly.

This sub-study ran almost every year from 1993 to 2000, then continued with less frequent follow-ups through to a dedicated 2005 hysterectomy study. **1999** is the one year the general survey and the Women's Health survey were both administered — the general sweep asked its own broader set of questions that year (see Clinical assessment begins, below), while the Women's Health survey continued its midlife health tracking in parallel.

[See the Women's Health sub-study questionnaires and PDFs on NSHD Questionnaires](#) →



Clinical assessment begins

1999–2016 · ages 53–70

From 1999 onward, the general sweeps introduced two additions that would define the rest of the study: a physical examination and cognitive tests, sat by study members directly rather than reported on a questionnaire. Alongside continuing questions on health, employment, and finance, this period added activities of daily living, physical capability, and — reflecting the ages now being reached — Rose Angina, intermittent claudication, heart trouble, cancer, and breast screening.

By the 2006–2010 and 2014–2016 sweeps, home visits had become standard, adding alcohol consumption, eating and sleeping habits, and a General Health Questionnaire measuring mental wellbeing alongside the physical assessment.

[See the 1999–2016 questionnaires and PDFs on NSHD Questionnaires →](#)



The Covid-19 impact survey

2020–2021 · age 74

Unlike every other sweep, this one wasn't run by the NSHD alone. In May 2020, the MRC Unit for Lifelong Health and Ageing and the UCL Centre for Longitudinal Studies ran a nationwide online survey examining the impact of the Covid-19 pandemic across five national longitudinal cohort studies together, including the NSHD.

A single questionnaire outside the normal rhythm of sweeps, it captured a moment in the study members' lives that no other sweep was designed to see.

[See the Covid-19 questionnaire and PDFs on NSHD Questionnaires →](#)



Later life and retirement

2022–2025 · ages 76–79

The most recent sweeps continue the clinical and cognitive assessment established from 1999 onward, now alongside questions squarely about later life: work and retirement, quality of life and social participation, and financial situation in older age — asked of a cohort that has, by this point, been answering the NSHD's questions for over three quarters of a century.

[See the 2022–2025 questionnaires and PDFs on NSHD Questionnaires →](#)